

A daily scan of national and South Yorkshire developments in education policy, inclusion, SEND, behaviour and accountability — weighted to primary and evidence sources, with links and a clear “so what for your school” line on the items that matter.

Useful? Forward it to a colleague. To join the circulation or partner with the network, [get in touch](#).

TOP LINE

- A quieter run after the weekend, but two inclusion threads worth knowing: DfE has shared draft worked examples of 'reasonable adjustments' schools should make for SEND pupils, and Sheffield's education and race equality partners met to reset joint commitments.
- Lincolnshire's De Aston School was placed in special measures after inspectors found suspensions weren't improving behaviour and more than half its SEND pupils were persistently absent - a sharp national illustration of the attendance/SEND/suspension triangle.

→ **For your school:** *Worth benchmarking your own SEND attendance and suspension data against this if you haven't recently.*

- Locally: the uniform dispute over abayas at Fir Vale Academy has been resolved, with new modesty-wear options agreed after a summer of internal exclusions for pupils wearing the garment.

DATES FOR THE DIARY

7 Oct 2026 — Barnsley Council cabinet meets to approve the revised £7.37m budget for the Worsbrough Bridge specialist SEND primary school.

8 Oct 2026 — DfE pupil premium quarter 2 payments for 2026/27 made to academies.

16 Oct 2026 — Midday deadline for Sheffield secondary school applications for September 2027 entry.

26-30 Oct 2026 — Sheffield schools' autumn half term.

■ SHEFFIELD: CITY RESETS RACE EQUALITY COMMITMENTS

▪ **Education leaders and partners met to recommit to race equality work.** Teachers, school leaders and partner organisations from across Sheffield came together last week to share learning and reaffirm joint commitments to race equality for children, young people and staff across the city's education system, building on the Anti Racist Education Alliance Sheffield (AREAS) and the city's Race Equality Commission work. (Sheffield City Council)

→ **For your school:** *Worth checking whether MAPs schools were represented and what commitments came out of it.*

■ NATIONAL: DFE TRIES TO DEFINE 'REASONABLE' ON SEND

▪ **Draft worked examples aim to clarify schools' Equality Act duties for SEND pupils.** DfE has shared draft documents with trust leaders setting out what could count as a reasonable, or unreasonable, adjustment for pupils with SEND - for example a supervised early-arrival window, or access to a low-stimulus space for pupils with sensory processing needs. It's part of the push to make mainstream schools more inclusive ahead of wider SEND reform. (Tes / DfE)

→ **For your school:** *Useful to flag to SENCOs shaping local adjustment policies ahead of formal guidance.*

■ NATIONAL: A CAUTIONARY TALE ON SEND, ATTENDANCE AND SUSPENSIONS

- **De Aston School, Lincolnshire, placed in special measures.** Ofsted found attendance had been below the national average for three years with no sign of improvement, more than half of SEND pupils persistently absent (exact figure not given), and suspensions not being used in a way that improved behaviour, with some pupils suspended repeatedly in a short space of time. Safeguarding and the sixth form met the expected standard. ([Grimsby Telegraph](#) / [Ofsted](#))

■ SHEFFIELD: FIR VALE UNIFORM DISPUTE RESOLVED

- **Abaya row settled with new modesty-wear options.** Fir Vale Academy has agreed three new clothing options - loose black trousers, a modesty skirt worn over trousers, or an ankle-length skirt - after weeks of pressure from parents and the local Muslim community over girls sent to internal exclusion for wearing abayas under its new uniform policy. ([Hyphen](#))

JARGON-BUSTER - REASONABLE ADJUSTMENTS

DfE's first worked examples (shared 1 Oct) try to pin down this fuzzy Equality Act duty.

Schools must take reasonable steps to remove disadvantage for disabled pupils. The draft guidance gives concrete examples for the first time - e.g. a supervised quiet arrival window, or a low-stimulus space for sensory needs.

MAPS IN PRACTICE – TOOL SPOTLIGHT: SCHOOL+

A strong inclusion strategy is only as good as the cohort picture beneath it.

School+ is the MAPs cohort-vulnerability framework — it maps who your at-risk pupils are and why, giving your inclusion strategy an evidence base rather than a wish list. [Explore School+](#)

■ SOURCES MONITORED

Weighted official- and evidence-first. X is monitored for early signals from official accounts and named commentators, and corroborated against a primary source before anything is included.

Source	Type	What we track
OFFICIAL & STATUTORY		
DfE / GOV.UK	Government	Policy, funding, statutory guidance and statistics
Ofsted	Government	Inspection framework, report cards, annual report
Explore Education Statistics	Government data	Exclusions, suspensions, attendance, census data
House of Commons Library	Parliament	Neutral briefings on bills and policy
RESEARCH & EVIDENCE		
Education Endowment Foundation	Research	Evidence-based guidance, incl. inclusive teaching
NFER	Research	Assessment, workforce, disadvantage
Education Policy Institute	Think tank	Policy analysis and the disadvantage gap
Institute for Fiscal Studies	Think tank	School funding and spending analysis
FFT Education Datalab	Data analysis	Data-driven analysis of attainment and exclusions
INCLUSION & PREVENTION SPECIALISTS		
The Difference	Charity	Whole-school inclusion; "Who's Losing Learning?"
IPPR	Think tank	Lost learning, exclusions, SEND reform
Youth Endowment Fund	Research	What works to prevent youth violence & exclusion
Centre for Social Justice	Think tank	Exclusion tracker and social-mobility policy
Whole School SEND	Network	SEND practice, resources and reviews
SECTOR PRESS & COMMENTARY		
Schools Week	Press	Breaking sector news and investigations
Tes	Press	Practice, policy and workforce
The Guardian (Education)	Press	National coverage and comment
X (monitored)	Social	DfE, Ofsted, EEF and named voices — corroborated before use

Source	Type	What we track
LOCAL & REGIONAL		
The Star (Sheffield)	Local press	Local schools and Ofsted outcomes
Sheffield City Council	Local government	Council decisions, funding and local strategy
South Yorkshire MCA & Careers Hub	Regional	Regional skills, careers and funding

Connect Daily is part of Sheffield Connect. Compiled by Andy Marsden, Sector Inclusion Lead.

For circulation across the network and partners. Figures reflect the latest published data at the date of this brief.